

PATIENT GUIDE

Dry Eye

Understanding, managing and treating:
A complete guide for patients of Samyak Drishti Eye Clinic



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WHAT IS DRY EYE?

Dry Eye Disease (DED) is a common condition in which your eyes are unable to stay properly lubricated, leaving the surface of your eye exposed and irritated.

Why Are Tears So Important?

Tears are working constantly, every moment your eyes are open. Each time you blink, a fresh tear film spreads across the eye — doing four essential things:

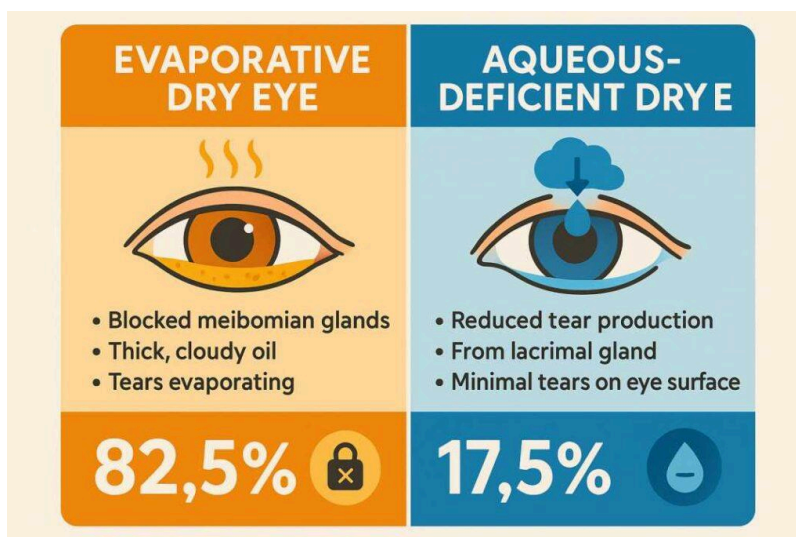
- **Lubricates the eye**, so your eyelids glide smoothly and stay comfortable
- **Protects the eye surface** from dust, allergens, microbes, and environmental irritants
- **Nourishes the cornea** – which has no blood vessels and depends entirely on tears for oxygen and nutrients
- **Maintains clear vision** – even minor tear film instability causes blurring and visual fluctuation

Without a healthy tear film, even simple tasks like reading, driving, or using a screen can become uncomfortable.

Why Us?

Dr Sujal Shah has over 30 years of experience managing the full spectrum of ocular surface disease, trusted by ophthalmologists and doctors for their own care

TYPES OF DRY EYE



COMMON SYMPTOMS

Dry Eye can feel different from person to person. You may experience some or all of the following:

- **Burning or stinging sensation:** a persistent feeling of heat or irritation in the eye
- **Grittiness:** the uncomfortable feeling that something is in your eye, like a grain of sand
- **Redness:** the whites of your eyes may appear pink or red, especially by end of day
- **Blurred or fluctuating vision:** hazy sight that may temporarily clear after blinking
- **Sensitivity to light (photophobia):** bright lights or screens may feel uncomfortable or painful
- **Watery or teary eyes:** when the eye is dry, the brain triggers a flood of thin reflex tears. These don't solve the underlying problem, but they are a very common symptom

Note: Symptoms often worsen later in the day, in air-conditioned environments, after prolonged screen use, or in windy/dry conditions.

CAUSES & RISK FACTORS

Dry Eye is rarely caused by a single factor. Most people develop it due to a combination of the following influences:

Lifestyle

- Prolonged screen use – reduces blink rate significantly
- Air conditioning and indoor heating – dry air accelerates tear evaporation
- Contact lens wear – lenses absorb the tear film and reduce moisture
- Smoking or exposure to second-hand smoke and pollution
- Insufficient water intake / dehydration

Medical & Hormonal

- Ageing – tear production naturally decreases from your 40s onward
- Hormonal changes – menopause, pregnancy, oral contraceptives
- Diabetes, thyroid disorders, rheumatoid arthritis
- Autoimmune conditions such as Sjögren's Syndrome or Lupus
- Meibomian Gland Dysfunction (MGD) – the leading structural cause
- Previous eye surgery (e.g. LASIK) – can affect tear production

Medications

- Antihistamines and decongestants
- Antidepressants and antianxiety medications
- Blood pressure medications (especially beta-blockers)
- Diuretics, certain acne medications (isotretinoin), HRT

Environmental

- Dry, low-humidity environments or high altitude
- Frequent air travel (cabin air is extremely dry)
- Windy, dusty, or polluted surroundings

If you are on any long-term medications, let your doctor know — they may be a contributing factor.

HOW IS DRY EYE DIAGNOSED?

A dry eye assessment at Samyak Drishti Eye Clinic is simple, painless, and usually completed within a single visit. There is nothing to worry about — none of the tests cause discomfort.

Step 1: Symptom Discussion	Your doctor will ask about your symptoms: when they started, what makes them better or worse, your daily routine, and any medications you take. There are no right or wrong answers — the more openly you share, the better your doctor can help.
Step 2: Tear Film Evaluation	Your doctor will assess the quality and quantity of your tears, including how long the tear film stays stable before breaking up (Tear Break-Up Time) and how much tear volume your eyes produce. A safe, temporary dye may be used to highlight any dry patches on the eye surface.
Step 3: Eye Surface Examination	Using a slit lamp (a magnified microscope), your doctor will examine your cornea, conjunctiva, and eyelid margins for signs of inflammation, gland blockage, or surface damage.

TREATMENT OPTIONS

The good news: Dry Eye is very manageable. Treatment is tailored to the type and severity of your condition — starting with simple at-home measures and progressing to clinical options where needed.

A. At-Home Care (First Line of Management)

- **Artificial Tears/Lubricating Drops:** Replenish the tear film and provide immediate relief. Always choose preservative-free drops for frequent use (more than 4 times daily).
- **Warm Compresses:** Apply to closed eyelids for 10 minutes daily. Softens the oils in Meibomian glands, improving oil flow and reducing evaporation — especially effective for Evaporative Dry Eye.
- **Eyelid Hygiene:** Gently clean the eyelid margins using a mild lid scrub or diluted baby shampoo on a cotton pad. Removes debris and bacteria that block glands and worsen symptoms.
- **The 20-20-20 Screen Rule:** Every 20 minutes of screen use, look at something at least 20 feet (6 metres) away for 20 seconds. Encourages full blinks and refreshes the tear film.

B. Medical Treatments (Prescribed by Your Doctor)

- **Anti-inflammatory drops** (e.g. cyclosporine or lifitegrast): reduce inflammation on the eye surface, which is often both a cause and consequence of dry eye
- **Corticosteroid drops:** for short-term relief during flare-ups
- **Omega-3 supplements** (fish oil or flaxseed oil): improve the quality of the oil layer in the tear film; strong clinical evidence for benefit

C. In-Clinic Procedures (For Persistent or Advanced Cases)

- **Punctal Plugs (Tear Duct Plugs):** tiny biocompatible plugs inserted painlessly into the tear drainage openings at the corner of your eyelids. Slows tear drainage so more natural tears remain on the eye surface. Can be temporary (dissolvable) or semi-permanent.
- **Meibomian Gland Expression:** controlled heat and pressure to clear blocked oil glands and restore the natural oil supply to the tear film.
- **Intense Pulsed Light (IPL) Therapy:** gentle light-based treatment applied around the eyelids. Reduces inflammation and unclogs Meibomian glands; particularly effective alongside skin conditions like rosacea.
- **LipiFlow:** A specialised device delivers controlled warmth and gentle pulsating massage directly to the inner and outer eyelids, helping to clear blocked meibomian glands in a single in-clinic session.

Note: Dr Sujal performs LipiFlow at Sir HN Reliance Foundation Hospital

Your doctor at Samyak Drishti will advise which option — or combination of options — is most appropriate for you.

DAILY TIPS TO MANAGE DRY EYE

Managing Dry Eye well is largely about consistent daily habits. These small adjustments make a meaningful difference:

- **Blink consciously and completely:** during screen use, we blink up to 60% less than normal, and often incompletely. Every few minutes, take 5–10 slow, deliberate blinks
- **Stay well hydrated:** aim for at least 8 glasses of water daily; dehydration reduces tear volume
- **Use a humidifier:** especially in air-conditioned or heated rooms. Keeping indoor humidity at 40–60% significantly reduces tear evaporation
- **Wear wraparound sunglasses outdoors:** shields eyes from wind, dust, and UV exposure
- **Position your screen below eye level:** a slightly downward gaze reduces eye surface exposure and evaporation
- **Take regular breaks from contact lenses:** give your eyes rest days; never wear lenses longer than prescribed
- **Eat an eye-healthy diet:** oily fish, flaxseeds, walnuts, and leafy greens are rich in Omega-3 and antioxidants that support eye health
- **Avoid direct airflow:** sit away from air-conditioning vents, fans, and car vents directed at your face

WHEN TO SEE A DOCTOR

While many people manage mild dry eye with over-the-counter drops, please do not delay seeking professional care if you experience any of the following:

- Symptoms that persist or worsen despite regular use of lubricating eye drops
- Eye pain or a feeling of pressure in the eye
- Sudden or significant changes in vision
- Increasing redness, swelling, or discharge from the eye
- Sensitivity to light that is new or worsening
- Difficulty keeping your eyes open or completing daily tasks comfortably
- Dry eye alongside a known autoimmune condition, hormonal change, or new medication

Early assessment leads to better outcomes. Untreated Dry Eye can cause long-term damage to the eye surface – it is always worth getting it checked.

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

1. Is Dry Eye a permanent condition?

For many people, Dry Eye is a chronic condition requiring ongoing management rather than a one-time cure. With the right treatment plan, most patients experience significant and sustained relief. In some cases – such as post-surgical or medication-related dry eye – the condition can improve once the underlying cause is addressed.

2. Can screen time cause Dry Eye?

Yes. One of the most common triggers today. Screen use drops our blink rate dramatically and causes incomplete blinks, meaning the tear film isn't regularly refreshed. The 20-20-20 rule and conscious blinking are highly effective countermeasures.

3. Are lubricating eye drops safe daily?

Yes. Reservative-free lubricating drops are safe for long-term, frequent use. If you need drops more than 4 times a day, a clinical assessment is recommended to identify the underlying cause.

4. Can diet help?

Absolutely. Omega-3 fatty acids (oily fish, walnuts, flaxseed) have strong evidence for improving tear film quality. Staying well hydrated is equally important.

5. Can Dry Eye affect vision permanently?

If left untreated long-term, chronic dry eye can cause corneal surface damage that may affect vision. With proper care, the vast majority of patients do not develop serious complications.

6. Is Dry Eye more common in women?

Yes — women are at higher risk due to hormonal fluctuations during menopause, pregnancy, and with the use of contraceptives or HRT. Hormones directly influence tear production and composition.

7. Can children get Dry Eye?

Yes, though less common. In children and teenagers, the main cause is prolonged device use. If your child regularly complains of eye discomfort, redness, or blurred vision, a check-up is recommended.

Contact & Appointments

Book Your Dry Eye Assessment

Don't let discomfort become your normal.

At Samyak Drishti, you will receive a thorough tear film evaluation, a clear diagnosis, and a personalised treatment plan suited to your lifestyle and needs.

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This guide is intended for patient education only and does not replace personalised medical advice. Always consult your doctor at Samyak Drishti Eye Clinic for guidance specific to your eyes and health.